Our rising excitement at a potentially big news break didn't match the end product. The Congress put up a short video on its website of Sonia addressing the country and warning that the BJP would destroy the 'Bharatiyata', the 'Hindustaniyat' of the country if it came to power. Looking a little weary and speaking in halting Hindi, Sonia with this short intervention was never going to be enough to halt Modi's march.

The Gandhi family brand had plummeted in recent months. With her accented Hindi increasingly met with howls of derision, Sonia's weak harking to the Congress version of Bharatiyata sounded only like the wail of a rotten old order, far removed from the restless dynamism of the times. Just days before her Bharatiyata statement, Sonia had secretly met Syed Ahmed Bukhari, the Shahi Imam of Jama Masjid. The Shahi Imam had appealed to Muslim voters to stand with the Congress and stay away from the 'communal' Modi. That a discredited cleric was being used to woo the minorities only reflected the bankruptcy of the Congress's tattered secular vision. The country had moved well beyond the fear that a Modi-led government would create a divided India. Her instinctive aversion to Hindutva politics notwithstanding, Sonia appeared to be caught in a time warp. This election was being fought on who offered a better governance vision and, importantly, on who could revive the economy, not by stirring past memories of a Hindu–Muslim conflict.

To this day, I maintain that the Congress just failed to understand the Modi phenomenon, failed to grasp that he had presented himself as perhaps India's first true post-liberalization politician. The social changes set in motion after the great economic transformation of 1991 (ironically, kick-started by the Congress) created generations of Indians for whom wealth creation and upward mobility became the fundamental markers of the good life, even as their licence-permit era parents' and grandparents' ambitions may have centred on government jobs and academic qualifications. A new India had bounded into existence—restless, aspirational, with access to the information superhighway, the silicon economies, multinationals and global opportunities. The explosion of purchasing power, the shopping mall culture, the booming service industry, new industries in leisure and tourism